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Tournament Preparation and Competitive Psychology

Prepare openings, energy, clock habits, resilience, and post-game learning

COURSE BOOK

20 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

How to Use This Course

ONE CHAPTER, FOUR PASSES

1. Read the position without moving pieces. 2. State your plan and the opponent's counterplay. 3. Study the decision rules. 4. Close the book and reconstruct the position from memory.

RETRIEVAL SCHEDULE

Review the chapter the next day, one week later, and after a game that reaches a similar structure. Retrieval is more valuable than rereading.

BOARD ROUTINE

Opponent's threat - forcing moves - loose pieces - worst piece - central break - best reply - choose and stop.

The course book explains each model position. The separate workbook forces recall, prediction, and self-scoring. Use the book first, then attempt the matching workbook page without looking back.

Engine evaluations are intentionally not the lesson. The aim is to store human decision rules that remain useful when the exact move order changes.

Course Map

MODULE	CHAPTERS
TOURNAMENT PREPARATION AND COMPETITIVE PSYCHOLOGY	20

PAGE 3



Improving the least useful piece can improve every other piece at once.

JOB: What useful task is this piece doing?; SQUARES: How many safe, relevant squares exist?; RESTRICTION: Which pawn or piece limits it?; PATH: Can it improve without creating weakness?

Replace 'I need an active move' with 'Improve the piece with no future.'; Replace 'A developed piece is fine' with 'Judge its job, not its location.'; Replace 'Two moves is too slow' with 'Use a route when the position is quiet.'

MEMORY RULE

When you cannot find a plan, improve your worst piece.

01. Decision Framework

Find Your Worst Piece

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	SCAN: Look at every piece once.; RANK: Name the least useful piece.; DIAGNOSE: Find what restricts it.; ROUTE: Choose its best realistic square.; VERIFY: Check that tactics allow the plan.
PIECE JOB	ACTIVITY: Count useful squares, not distance from the center.; PURPOSE: A piece needs a job connected to the position.; ROUTE: The best improvement may require two quiet moves.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	BOTTLENECK: One bad piece can spoil a good position.; JOB: Activity must serve a purpose.; ROUTE: Quiet improvement can be concrete.; PATIENCE: Do not attack before your pieces can help.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

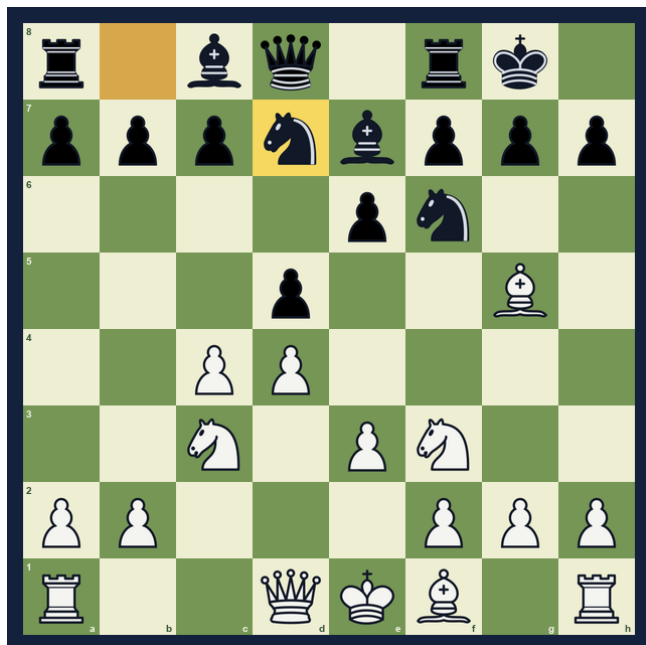
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: When you cannot find a plan, improve your worst piece.

02. Evaluate Before Choosing A Move



TOURNAMENT PREPARATION AND COMPETITIVE PSYCHOLOGY

READ THE POSITION

Decide what the position needs before deciding how to provide it.

PRIMARY PLAN

SAFETY: Are there urgent threats to either king?;
STRUCTURE: What will remain true after exchanges?;
ACTIVITY: Whose pieces have better jobs?; PRIORITY: Which imbalance matters most now?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'I see a move I like' with 'Give the position a diagnosis first.'; Replace 'Material is equal' with 'Compare activity, safety, and structure.'; Replace 'Everything matters' with 'Choose the most urgent imbalance.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Be7 5. Bg5 O-O 6. e3 Nbd7

MEMORY RULE

A good move is easier to find after you know what good means.

02. Decision Framework

Evaluate Before Choosing A Move

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	PAUSE: Do not generate moves immediately.; SAFETY: Rule out tactical urgency.; COMPARE: Check structure and activity.; PRIORITY: Name one thing to improve or attack.; GENERATE: Choose moves that serve that priority.
PIECE JOB	SAFETY: Check kings and immediate tactical instability first.; STRUCTURE: Find lasting strengths, weaknesses, and pawn breaks.; ACTIVITY: Compare which pieces are useful and which are restricted.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	DIAGNOSE: Understand before prescribing a move.; COMPARE: Evaluation is always relative.; PRIORITY: One imbalance usually matters most.; PURPOSE: Candidate moves should solve a named problem.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: A good move is easier to find after you know what good means.

03. Build A Candidate List



TOURNAMENT PREPARATION AND COMPETITIVE PSYCHOLOGY

READ THE POSITION

Choose two or three moves from different categories before entering a line.

PRIMARY PLAN

FORCING: Is there a sound forcing move?; IMPROVING: Which piece or pawn can improve?; PREVENTIVE: What opponent idea deserves attention?; CHOOSE: Keep the best two or three candidates.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Calculate the first idea' with 'List candidates before analyzing lines.'; Replace 'Checks always come first' with 'Include only meaningful forcing moves.'; Replace 'Find ten possibilities' with 'Keep a small, contrasting shortlist.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 dxc4 5. a4 Bf5 6. e3 e6 7. Bxc4

MEMORY RULE

A short candidate list prevents both tunnel vision and wasted time.

03. Decision Framework

Build A Candidate List

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	DIAGNOSE: Name the position's priority.; GENERATE: Find forcing, improving, and preventive moves.; SHORTLIST: Keep no more than three.; CALCULATE: Test the most critical line first.; COMPARE: Return to the same final criteria.
PIECE JOB	FORCING: Include checks or captures only when they have a purpose.; IMPROVING: Find a move that improves your position without forcing.; PREVENTIVE: Consider a move that limits the opponent's main idea.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	DIVERSE: Candidates should solve the problem differently.; SMALL: Two or three moves are usually enough.; FAIR: Calculate each serious candidate honestly.; COMPARE: Use one evaluation standard for every line.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

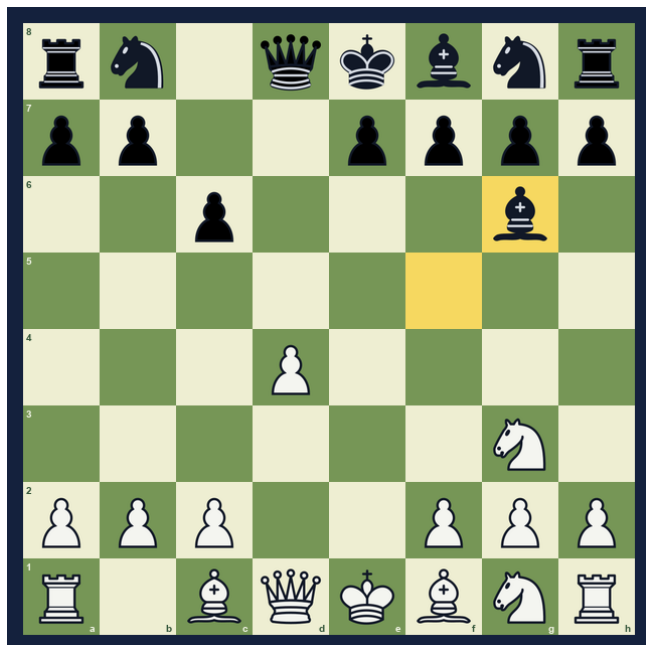
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: A short candidate list prevents both tunnel vision and wasted time.

04. What Is The Opponent'S Idea?



TOURNAMENT PREPARATION AND COMPETITIVE PSYCHOLOGY

READ THE POSITION

Find the opponent's strongest useful continuation, then decide whether it must be stopped.

PRIMARY PLAN

THREAT: What happens if I make a waiting move?;
IMPROVE: Which of their pieces wants a better square?;
URGENCY: Can the idea wait one move?; RESPONSE: Can my move answer it while improving?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'They attacked something' with 'Ask what happens if you ignore it.'; Replace 'I must stop their idea' with 'Judge whether it is actually urgent.'; Replace 'Defense means retreat' with 'Prefer a useful move with two purposes.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 dxe4 4. Nxe4 Bf5 5. Ng3 Bg6

MEMORY RULE

See their idea clearly, then respond by choice rather than fear.

04. Decision Framework

What Is The Opponent'S Idea?

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	WAIT: Imagine passing your turn.; PREDICT: Name their strongest next move.; VALUE: Judge what that move would gain.; DECIDE: Stop, delay, or ignore it.; MULTIPURPOSE: Choose a response that also improves.
PIECE JOB	THREAT: A real threat changes material, king safety, or structure.; IMPROVEMENT: A quiet move may activate their worst piece.; URGENCY: Some ideas can be met after you improve your own position.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	PREDICT: Name one serious opponent idea.; TEST: Use a waiting move to expose urgency.; SELECT: Not every idea deserves prevention.; IMPROVE: The best defense often serves your plan too.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: See their idea clearly, then respond by choice rather than fear.

05. Prepare The Pawn Break



TOURNAMENT PREPARATION AND COMPETITIVE PSYCHOLOGY

READ THE POSITION

Support the break, occupy the lines it will open, and calculate the opponent's best reaction.

PRIMARY PLAN

SUPPORT: Is the breaking pawn adequately supported?;
 PLACEMENT: Which pieces improve after lines open?;
 RESPONSES: Test capture, advance, and refusal.; OUTCOME:
 Which structure remains after each reply?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'The break is thematic' with 'Check whether the pieces are ready now.'; Replace 'They must capture' with 'Calculate advance and refusal too.'; Replace 'Open position is good' with 'Name which pieces actually improve.'

REFERENCE LINE 1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nd2 c5 4. exd5 exd5 5. Ngf3 Nc6

MEMORY RULE

The best pawn break is prepared before it becomes urgent.

05. Decision Framework

Prepare The Pawn Break

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	NAME: Identify the structural break.; PLACE: Move pieces onto future lines.; SUPPORT: Reinforce the advancing pawn.; TEST: Calculate all three responses.; BREAK: Play it when every reply helps.
PIECE JOB	SUPPORT: The advancing pawn needs enough protection or tactical justification.; PLACEMENT: Rooks and bishops should face the lines that will open.; RESPONSE: The opponent may capture, advance, or ignore the break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	PERMANENT: Pawn breaks cannot be taken back.; PREPARE: Place pieces before opening lines.; RESPONSES: Capture is only one possible reply.; RESULT: Evaluate the resulting structure, not the push.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: The best pawn break is prepared before it becomes urgent.

06. Stop Counterplay Without Passivity



TOURNAMENT PREPARATION AND COMPETITIVE PSYCHOLOGY

READ THE POSITION

Identify the freeing break, invasion square, or active piece that gives the opponent play.

PRIMARY PLAN

SOURCE: What creates their active play?; CONTROL: Can one move block or discourage it?; PROGRESS: Does the move improve your own position?; RELEASE: What happens if they achieve the break?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Stop every threat' with 'Find the one source of activity.'; Replace 'Defend with retreat' with 'Use control, trades, or a useful blockade.'; Replace 'Keep attacking' with 'Spend one move removing their best resource.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. Nf3 Nf6 3. Bf4 e6 4. e3 Bd6 5. Bg3 O-O 6. Bd3

MEMORY RULE

Good prevention does not stop your game; it clears the road for it.

06. Decision Framework

Stop Counterplay Without Passivity

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	PREDICT: Name their best active idea.; TRACE: Find the break or square it needs.; BLOCK: Choose the smallest effective restraint.; IMPROVE: Make the move serve your plan too.; CONTINUE: Return to conversion after control.
PIECE JOB	SOURCE: Counterplay usually depends on one break, file, or piece.; CONTROL: A single square can sometimes stop the entire idea.; PROGRESS: Your restraining move should preserve a path forward.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	ONE SOURCE: Counterplay is often structurally narrow.; MINIMUM: Use the least passive effective move.; DUAL PURPOSE: Restriction should also improve.; RETURN: Once controlled, continue your own plan.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Good prevention does not stop your game; it clears the road for it.

07. Forcing Moves With Purpose



TOURNAMENT PREPARATION AND COMPETITIVE PSYCHOLOGY

READ THE POSITION

Generate forcing moves, then reject the ones that improve the opponent's position.

PRIMARY PLAN

FORCE: How many sensible replies remain?; RESULT: Where does the king or recapturing piece land?; PURPOSE: What does the move actually gain?; EXIT: Can you continue if the attack ends?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Always check first' with 'Test whether the check improves their king.'; Replace 'Capture because it is forcing' with 'Evaluate the recapture and resulting activity.'; Replace 'Keep the initiative' with 'Know where the forcing sequence ends.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. d3 d6 7. c3 O-O

MEMORY RULE

Use forcing moves to simplify the tree, then let evaluation choose the move.

07. Decision Framework

Forcing Moves With Purpose

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	LIST: Notice checks, captures, and direct threats.; FILTER: Remove moves with an obvious good reply.; FOLLOW: Calculate the opponent's most resistant answer.; STOP: Reach a stable position.; EVALUATE: Judge the result without excitement.
PIECE JOB	REPLIES: A forcing move reduces the opponent's reasonable choices.; RESULT: The final position still decides whether the move is good.; PURPOSE: Every check or capture should serve a tactical or positional aim.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	ATTENTION: Forcing moves deserve inspection, not obedience.; KING: A check may improve the king's location.; RECAPTURE: A capture can activate the opponent.; END: Know the position after the forcing moves stop.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

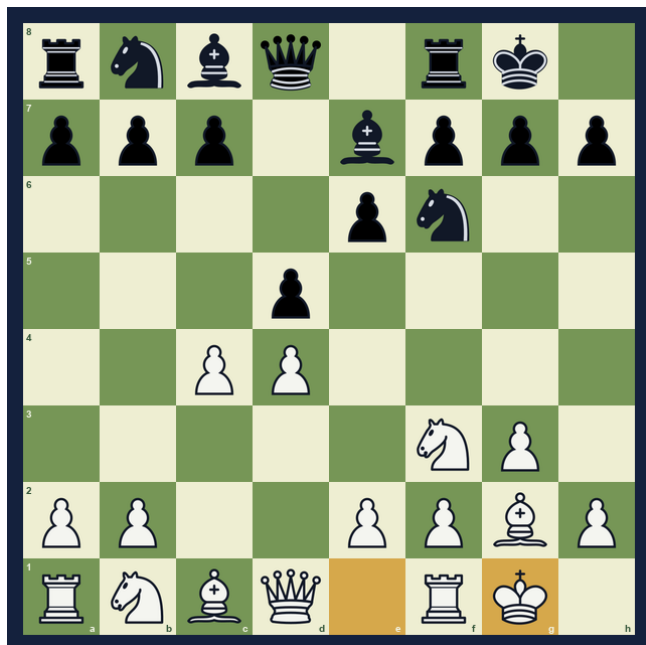
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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Use forcing moves to simplify the tree, then let evaluation choose the move.

08. Calculate Until The Position Is Quiet



TOURNAMENT PREPARATION AND COMPETITIVE PSYCHOLOGY

READ THE POSITION

Continue until checks, captures, and immediate threats no longer control the next move.

PRIMARY PLAN

FORCING: Does either side still have a forcing reply?; SAFETY: Are kings and major pieces stable?; EVALUATE: Who is better in the quiet position?; COMPARE: Apply the same stopping point to other lines.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'I saw three moves' with 'Continue if the position is still forcing.'; Replace 'I won material' with 'Check whether king safety or recapture changes it.'; Replace 'The line feels good' with 'Name the final stable evaluation.'

REFERENCE LINE 1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. g3 Be7 5. Bg2 O-O 6. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Do not stop because the line is long; stop because the position is stable.

08. Decision Framework

Calculate Until The Position Is Quiet

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	ENTER: Begin with the critical candidate.; FORCE: Follow the most demanding reply.; CLEAN: Resolve checks and captures.; STABILIZE: Reach a position with normal choices.; JUDGE: Evaluate material, safety, and activity.
PIECE JOB	FORCING: Unanswered forcing moves mean the line is unfinished.; STABILITY: Material, king safety, and loose pieces must be understandable.; EVALUATION: Only a quiet position can be compared reliably.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	DEPTH: Count stability, not a fixed number of moves.; UNFINISHED: Forcing replies mean calculation must continue.; QUIET: Stable positions can be evaluated honestly.; CONSISTENT: Compare candidates at equivalent endpoints.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

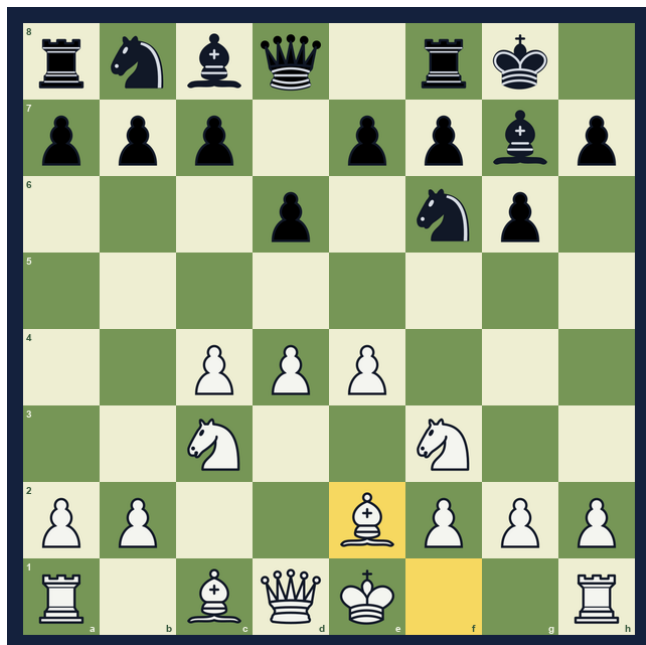
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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Do not stop because the line is long; stop because the position is stable.

09. Compare Final Positions



TOURNAMENT PREPARATION AND COMPETITIVE PSYCHOLOGY

READ THE POSITION

Compare material, king safety, activity, structure, and practical difficulty at the endpoint.

PRIMARY PLAN

MATERIAL: What exactly remains on the board?; SAFETY: Whose king faces lasting danger?; ACTIVITY: Which pieces have useful work?; PRACTICAL: Which position is easier to handle?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'That line was forcing' with 'Judge its endpoint, not its drama.'; Replace 'The engine-like move wins a pawn' with 'Count activity and king safety too.'; Replace 'Both are equal' with 'Prefer the clearer practical plan.'

REFERENCE LINE 1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2

MEMORY RULE

Choose the position you want to play, not the line you enjoyed calculating.

09. Decision Framework

Compare Final Positions

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	FINISH: Reach a stable endpoint for line one.; LABEL: Give it a short evaluation.; REPEAT: Calculate line two to equal stability.; SCORE: Use the same four criteria.; CHOOSE: Select the best playable result.
PIECE JOB	MATERIAL: Count what remains after all forced exchanges.; QUALITY: Compare safety, activity, and durable weaknesses.; PRACTICALITY: Prefer positions whose plan is clear and errors are less costly.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	ENDPOINT: Moves are only a route to a position.; SAME TEST: Evaluate every line with equal criteria.; WHOLE BOARD: A pawn gain may cost activity.; PLAYABLE: Practical clarity has genuine value.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

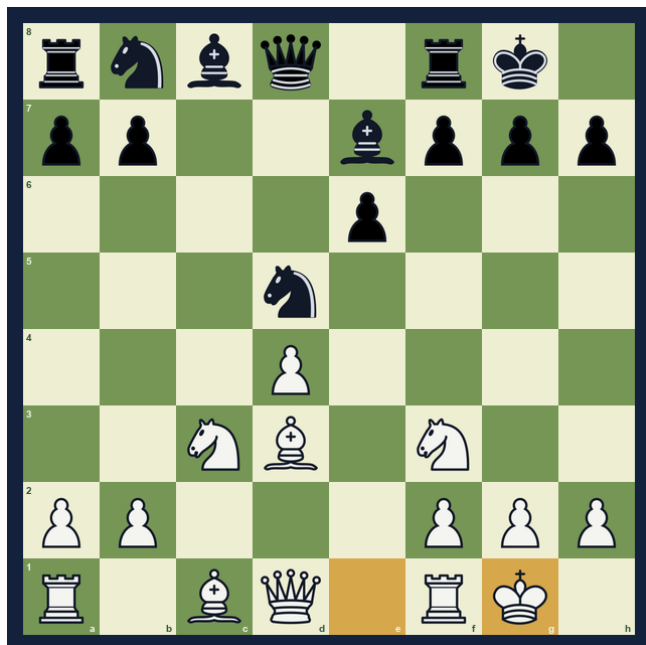
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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Choose the position you want to play, not the line you enjoyed calculating.

10. Stop Calculating Ghost Threats



TOURNAMENT PREPARATION AND COMPETITIVE PSYCHOLOGY

READ THE POSITION

Check access, consequence, and timing before investing calculation time.

PRIMARY PLAN

ACCESS: Is the route legal and unobstructed?
 CONSEQUENCE: What exactly is won or threatened?
 TIMING: How many moves does the idea require?
 RESPONSE: Is there a simple answer if it happens?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'That move looks dangerous' with 'State the exact consequence.'; Replace 'I should prevent it now' with 'Check whether they can execute it in time.'; Replace 'Calculate every attacking move' with 'Reject illegal or harmless ideas immediately.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c6 2. d4 d5 3. exd5 cxd5 4. c4 Nf6 5. Nc3 e6 6. Nf3 Be7 7. cxd5 Nxd5 8. Bd3 O-O 9. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Fear becomes manageable when you force it to become specific.

10. Decision Framework

Stop Calculating Ghost Threats

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	NAME: Say the feared move precisely.; VERIFY: Check path, legality, and protection.; DAMAGE: Describe the concrete result.; ANSWER: Find the simplest adequate response.; MOVE ON: Spend time elsewhere if it is harmless.
PIECE JOB	ACCESS: Can the threatening piece reach the square legally?; CONSEQUENCE: What concrete damage occurs if the move is played?; TIMING: Does the opponent have time, or can you create something stronger?
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	EXACT: A vague threat is not yet a threat.; LEGAL: Geometry and occupied squares matter.; DAMAGE: Name what the move accomplishes.; TIME: Reject harmless ideas before calculating them.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Fear becomes manageable when you force it to become specific.

11. Calculate Defensively



TOURNAMENT PREPARATION AND COMPETITIVE PSYCHOLOGY

READ THE POSITION

Identify what makes the threat work, then block, trade, move, or counterattack that element.

PRIMARY PLAN

MECHANISM: What exactly makes the threat work?;
 OPTIONS: Can you move, block, trade, or counter?;
 RESISTANCE: Choose their strongest continuation.; END: Is the resulting position actually safe?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Save the attacked piece' with 'Break the mechanism behind the threat.'; Replace 'Defend the target again' with 'Consider trading the attacker instead.'; Replace 'Any move that survives' with 'Evaluate the position after the danger ends.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. Nc3 Be7 5. Bg5 O-O 6. e3 Nbd7 7. Qc2 c5 8. cxd5 exd5 9. Bd3

MEMORY RULE

Good defense removes the threat's engine, not only its visible target.

11. Decision Framework

Calculate Defensively

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	DEFINE: State the threat precisely.; DISSECT: Find its necessary line or defender.; GENERATE: Use all four defensive methods.; TEST: Give the opponent maximum resistance.; STABILIZE: Choose the safest playable result.
PIECE JOB	MECHANISM: A threat depends on a line, defender, target, or move order.; OPTIONS: Defense includes moving, blocking, trading, and counterattacking.; RESIDUE: After surviving, avoid a position with a different fatal weakness.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	MECHANISM: Attack the reason the threat works.; FOUR METHODS: Move, block, trade, or counterattack.; BEST REPLY: Do not defend against a cooperative opponent.; AFTERWARD: Survival must lead to a playable position.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Good defense removes the threat's engine, not only its visible target.

12. When To Calculate Deeply



TOURNAMENT PREPARATION AND COMPETITIVE PSYCHOLOGY

READ THE POSITION

Calculate deeply when the move is forcing, irreversible, or changes the evaluation sharply.

PRIMARY PLAN

IRREVERSIBLE: Will the move permanently change structure or material?; UNSTABLE: Are forcing moves dominating?; CHOICES: Do candidates lead to different positions?; CLOCK: Can the decision justify the time cost?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Calculate every candidate' with 'Screen moves before spending time.'; Replace 'Think longest when confused' with 'Look for critical features first.'; Replace 'Save all my time' with 'Invest it at irreversible crossroads.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5 Be7 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd3 Nbd7 8. Qc2 Re8 9. Nge2 Nf8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Use your clock on decisions that will shape the rest of the game.

12. Decision Framework

When To Calculate Deeply

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	SCREEN: Check for tactical or structural instability.; SHORTLIST: Keep two or three serious moves.; BUDGET: Choose a reasonable time limit.; CALCULATE: Follow the most critical response.; DECIDE: Stop when one line is clearly preferable.
PIECE JOB	IRREVERSIBLE: Pawn moves, sacrifices, and exchanges cannot be undone.; UNSTABLE: Exposed kings and loose pieces make evaluation volatile.; CHOICE: Critical positions offer several plausible but different paths.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	CRITICAL: Some moves deserve far more time than others.; IRREVERSIBLE: Permanent changes require care.; SCREEN: Do not calculate bad candidates deeply.; STOP: A clear preference is enough to decide.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Use your clock on decisions that will shape the rest of the game.

13. Use Your Clock Like A Budget



TOURNAMENT PREPARATION AND COMPETITIVE PSYCHOLOGY

READ THE POSITION

Use fast routines for familiar positions and deliberate budgets for irreversible choices.

PRIMARY PLAN

BASLINE: What is your normal move budget?; **INVEST:** Is this position truly critical?; **RESERVE:** How much time must remain later?; **COMMIT:** When the budget ends, choose safely.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'More time finds truth' with 'Stop when one move is clearly adequate.'; Replace 'Think deeply in every position' with 'Use routines for ordinary decisions.'; Replace 'I will play fast later' with 'Protect a reserve before trouble begins.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. e5 c5 4. c3 Nc6 5. Nf3 Bd7 6. Be2 f6 7. O-O fxe5 8. dxe5 Qc7

MEMORY RULE

Do not try to spend the same care on decisions of different importance.

13. Decision Framework

Use Your Clock Like A Budget

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	GLANCE: Check clock and game phase.; CLASSIFY: Ordinary or critical position?; BUDGET: Set a mental stopping point.; DECIDE: Use the best evidence available.; RESET: Begin the next move fresh.
PIECE JOB	BASELINE: Ordinary moves need a modest default time.; INVESTMENT: Critical positions deserve a deliberate larger spend.; RESERVE: Keep enough time to make safe decisions near the end.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	RESOURCE: Time is part of the position.; UNEQUAL: Critical moves deserve unequal spending.; RESERVE: Late safety requires saved time.; ENOUGH: A sound move on time beats perfection too late.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

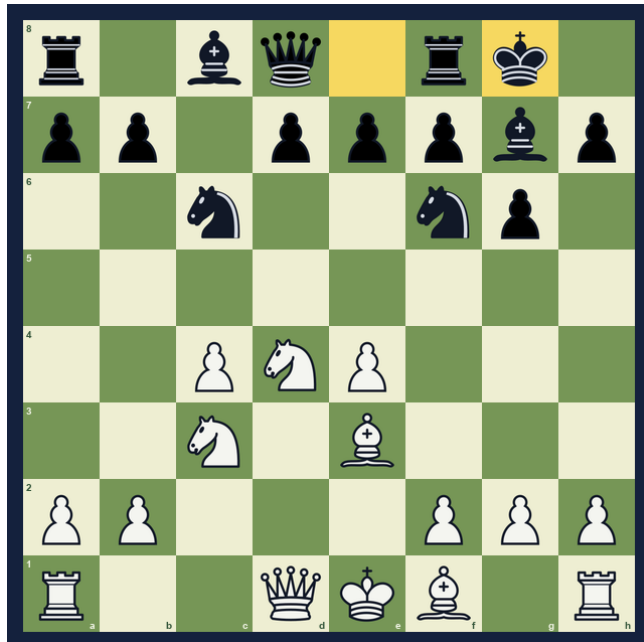
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Do not try to spend the same care on decisions of different importance.

14. Convert An Extra Pawn



TOURNAMENT PREPARATION AND COMPETITIVE PSYCHOLOGY

READ THE POSITION

Activate the king and pieces, restrict counterplay, then use the majority to create a passed pawn.

PRIMARY PLAN

KING: Can your king reach the stronger side?; EXCHANGE: Which enemy piece creates counterplay?; MAJORITY: Where can you create a passed pawn?; COUNTERPLAY: What active resource must be stopped?

OPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Push the extra pawn' with 'Improve the king before committing pawns.'; Replace 'Trade everything' with 'Exchange activity, not useful helpers.'; Replace 'Protect every pawn' with 'Permit harmless losses for a winning passer.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 g6 5. c4 Bg7 6. Be3 Nf6 7. Nc3 O-O

MEMORY RULE

An extra pawn becomes a win when the whole position helps it matter.

14. Decision Framework

Convert An Extra Pawn

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	ACTIVATE: Improve the king first.; RESTRICT: Remove the opponent's active resource.; EXCHANGE: Trade the piece that creates resistance.; CREATE: Use the majority to make a passer.; ESCORT: Advance with coordinated support.
PIECE JOB	KING: The king must help attack and escort pawns.; EXCHANGES: Trade active enemy pieces, not every piece automatically.; MAJORITY: Use the extra pawn to create a protected or distant passer.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	ACTIVITY: Material needs active help.; SELECTIVE: Not every exchange improves conversion.; PASSER: The extra pawn must gain a useful role.; CONTROL: Stop counterplay before racing.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

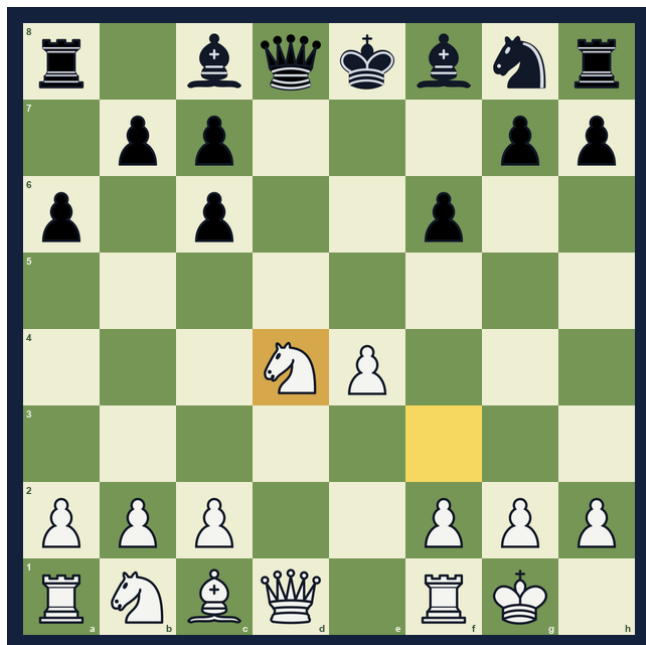
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: An extra pawn becomes a win when the whole position helps it matter.

15. Defend A Worse Position



TOURNAMENT PREPARATION AND COMPETITIVE PSYCHOLOGY

READ THE POSITION

Reduce the opponent's easiest plan while preserving one source of counterplay.

PRIMARY PLAN

PLAN: What is their easiest winning plan?; TRADE: Which exchange disrupts it most?; COUNTERPLAY: What active resource can you preserve?; FORTRESS: Can you build a stable defensive setup?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'I should wait' with 'Force the opponent to solve a new problem.'; Replace 'Trade anything' with 'Trade the piece that enables their plan.'; Replace 'Create random threats' with 'Preserve credible, sustainable counterplay.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Bxc6 dxc6 5. O-O f6 6. d4 exd4 7. Nxd4

MEMORY RULE

Defend the position by making the opponent prove every part of the win.

15. Decision Framework

Defend A Worse Position

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	ACCEPT: Evaluate the position without panic.; PREDICT: Name their simplest plan.; DISRUPT: Trade, blockade, or change structure.; ACTIVATE: Create one serious source of play.; RESIST: Make every step require accuracy.
PIECE JOB	RESISTANCE: Identify the plan they would choose with unlimited time.; TRADE: Exchange the piece that makes that plan simple.; COUNTERPLAY: Keep one credible threat or pawn break alive.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	NOT LOST: A disadvantage is an evaluation, not a result.; DIFFICULTY: Your job is to complicate conversion.; TARGETED TRADE: Remove the key winning piece.; ACTIVE: Keep one resource the opponent must respect.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Defend the position by making the opponent prove every part of the win.

16. When You Have No Idea What To Do



TOURNAMENT PREPARATION AND COMPETITIVE PSYCHOLOGY

READ THE POSITION

Remove immediate danger, improve the worst piece, or preserve useful options.

PRIMARY PLAN

SAFETY: Is anything loose or tactically vulnerable?; IMPROVE: Which piece has the least useful job?; FLEXIBLE: Which move preserves options?; OPPONENT: What idea should not be allowed?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'I need a plan' with 'Solve one concrete problem first.'; Replace 'Make a pawn move' with 'Prefer reversible piece improvement.'; Replace 'Copy a known idea' with 'Use what this position actually needs.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. e5 c5 4. c3 Nc6 5. Nf3 Qb6 6. Bd3 cxd4 7. cxd4 Bd7

MEMORY RULE

When you have no plan, make the position easier for your future self.

16. Decision Framework

When You Have No Idea What To Do

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	BREATHE: Stop demanding a perfect move.; SAFETY: Remove tactical defects.; IMPROVE: Help the worst piece.; PRESERVE: Avoid unnecessary pawn commitments.; PLAY: Choose a sound move and continue.
PIECE JOB	SAFETY: A safe position gives future plans time to appear.; IMPROVEMENT: One better piece can reveal the next step.; FLEXIBILITY: A noncommittal move can keep several plans available.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	SMALL: A useful move need not solve everything.; SAFE: Stability creates future opportunities.; REVERSIBLE: Piece moves preserve more options than pawn moves.; REAL: Respond to the position, not your memory.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: When you have no plan, make the position easier for your future self.

17. Recover From A Bad Opening



TOURNAMENT PREPARATION AND COMPETITIVE PSYCHOLOGY

READ THE POSITION

Finish development, protect the king, and challenge the opponent's most useful piece or space advantage.

PRIMARY PLAN

SAFETY: What immediate danger must be removed?; DEVELOP: Which undeveloped piece can join?; TRADE: Which enemy piece dominates the position?; BREAK: What pawn move could eventually free you?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'I must regain equality' with 'Aim for a stable playable position.'; Replace 'Attack to create chances' with 'Complete development before counterplay.'; Replace 'Avoid all exchanges' with 'Trade the piece that sustains their pressure.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 e5 6. Ndb5 d6 7. Bg5 a6 8. Na3 b5 9. Nd5 Be7

MEMORY RULE

A bad opening becomes survivable when you stop trying to erase it in one move.

17. Decision Framework

Recover From A Bad Opening

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	ACCEPT: Stop fighting the evaluation emotionally.; SECURE: Protect king and loose pieces.; DEVELOP: Bring every piece into the game.; REDUCE: Exchange the strongest enemy piece.; FREE: Prepare the structural break that creates room.
PIECE JOB	SAFETY: Stop immediate tactics and secure the king.; DEVELOPMENT: Bring unused pieces into defensive and active roles.; TRADE: Exchange the piece that makes the opponent's advantage easy.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	STABLE: Playable is the first recovery target.; ONE ERROR: Do not turn an opening mistake into several.; DEVELOP: Unused pieces cannot solve problems.; FREEING BREAK: Know the move that can restore space.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: A bad opening becomes survivable when you stop trying to erase it in one move.

18. Train Patterns, Not Answers



TOURNAMENT PREPARATION AND COMPETITIVE PSYCHOLOGY

READ THE POSITION

After solving, name what made the tactic or plan possible and what would remove it.

PRIMARY PLAN

TRIGGER: What feature first called for the move?;

MECHANISM: Why did the move work?; VARIATION: What change would make it fail?; RECALL: Can you explain it tomorrow without the board?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Memorize the solution' with 'Name the cue that should trigger it.'; Replace 'Solve more positions' with 'Review fewer positions more deeply.'; Replace 'The answer makes sense' with 'Change one feature and test the idea.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 e6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nc6 5. Nc3 Qc7 6. Be3 a6 7. Qd2 Nf6 8. O-O-O Bb4

MEMORY RULE

A pattern is not an answer you remember; it is a situation you recognize.

18. Decision Framework

Train Patterns, Not Answers

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	SOLVE: Find the move without hints.; NAME: State the trigger and mechanism.; CHANGE: Alter one defender, line, or square.; RETEST: Decide whether the idea still works.; RECALL: Review the lesson the next day.
PIECE JOB	TRIGGER: A loose piece, open line, or weak square starts recognition.; MECHANISM: The idea works through a pin, overload, route, or break.; VARIATION: Changing one feature tests whether you truly understand.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	CUE: Recognition begins with a visible feature.; WHY: Mechanisms transfer better than moves.; CONTRAST: A near-miss teaches the boundary.; SPACING: Delayed recall turns insight into memory.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

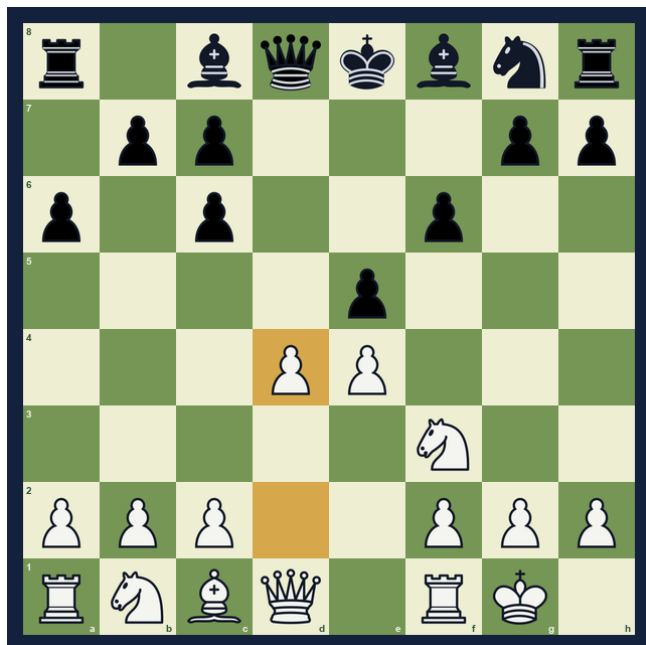
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: A pattern is not an answer you remember; it is a situation you recognize.

19. Build Your Personal Chess Manual



TOURNAMENT PREPARATION AND COMPETITIVE PSYCHOLOGY

READ THE POSITION

Convert each repeated error into a cue, a replacement question, and a training action.

PRIMARY PLAN

ERROR: What decision failed repeatedly?; CUE: What visible feature should alert you?; RULE: What short question replaces the mistake?; TRAIN: What exercise rehearses that question?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Collect lots of advice' with 'Keep only rules supported by your games.'; Replace 'Write long explanations' with 'Create one sentence usable at the board.'; Replace 'Move to the next lesson' with 'Train one rule for several games.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Bxc6 dxc6 5. O-O f6 6. d4

MEMORY RULE

The secrets of chess become less secret when you turn your own games into instructions.

19. Decision Framework

Build Your Personal Chess Manual

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	REVIEW: Find one recurring decision error.; CUE: Identify when it begins.; WRITE: Create a short replacement question.; PRACTICE: Use it deliberately for five games.; REVISE: Keep, change, or retire the rule.
PIECE JOB	EVIDENCE: Use mistakes that appeared in your own serious games.; RULE: Write one short instruction that can guide a decision.; REHEARSAL: Practice the rule in similar positions until it becomes automatic.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	PERSONAL: Your repeated errors define your curriculum.; SHORT: Board-ready rules must be memorable.; ONE AT A TIME: Focused practice changes behavior.; REVISE: A manual should grow with your chess.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

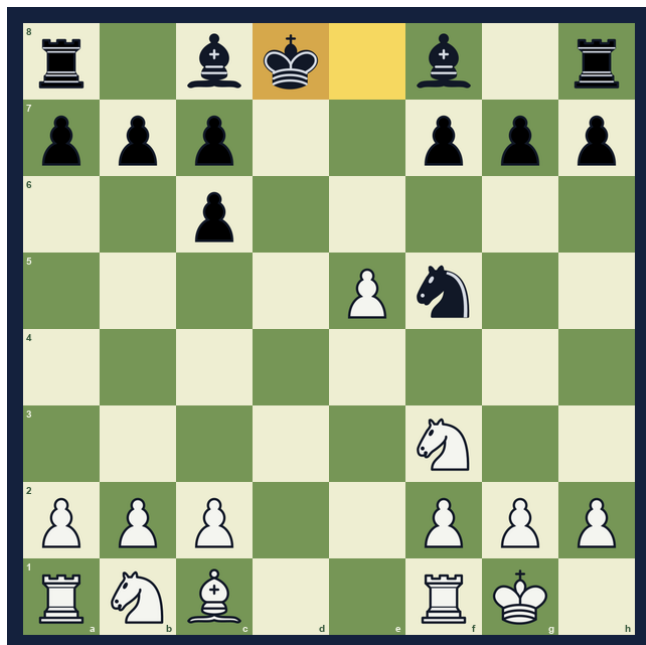
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: The secrets of chess become less secret when you turn your own games into instructions.

20. What Did The Last Move Change?



TOURNAMENT PREPARATION AND COMPETITIVE PSYCHOLOGY

READ THE POSITION

Study the square a piece left as carefully as the square it reached.

PRIMARY PLAN

LANDING: Inspect new attacks and blocks.; ABSENCE: Inspect the vacated square and lines.; PROTECTION: Notice defenders that disappeared.; INTENT: Name the likely next idea.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'They only developed' with 'Ask what became unguarded.'; Replace 'My plan still works' with 'Recheck the position after every move.'; Replace 'The threat is obvious' with 'Look for the quiet purpose too.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 Nf6 4. O-O Nxe4 5. d4 Nd6 6. Bxc6 dxc6 7. dxe5 Nf5 8. Qxd8+ Kxd8

MEMORY RULE

Read the change first; make your plan second.

20. Decision Framework

What Did The Last Move Change?

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	RESET: Forget your previous plan briefly.; LANDING: Scan attacks from the new square.; VACATED: Trace opened files and diagonals.; DEFENDERS: Recount critical protection.; RESPOND: Choose a move for the new position.
PIECE JOB	ARRIVAL: What does the moved piece attack from its new square?; DEPARTURE: What line or square did it stop protecting?; PURPOSE: What future idea became easier for the opponent?
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	BOTH ENDS: Every move changes two squares.; LINES: Vacated squares often reveal tactics.; DEFENDERS: Protection can vanish silently.; INTENT: Predict the next move, not only this one.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Read the change first; make your plan second.

Course Completion Test

Choose ten chapters at random. Rebuild each reference position, name both sides' plans, identify the critical break, and state the trade filter without reopening the chapter.

Score one point for the structure, one for your plan, one for counterplay, one for the break, and one for the memory rule. Forty out of fifty means the knowledge is usable; below forty means retrieval practice should continue.

FINAL PRINCIPLE

A course is complete when its ideas appear in your decisions, not when its pages have been read.